

Kompromat

Matthew Baker

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After hacking Fancy Bear/Cozy Bear he drove from San Juan to a house in the jungle along the coast. An ultramodern getaway. Airbnb. The house had a tatami platform bed and a leather sofa and a leather recliner and a potted jade plant and bamboo shades raised to varying positions in the windows, ceiling-to-floor, overlooking a white-sand beach. Some yellow-green parakeets were perched in the sunshine on the terrace. Dropping the duffel bag onto the bed, he took out the computer that he had used for the hack, a Framework DIY equipped with a 1TB expansion card flashed with Tails OS, and he erased Tails OS from the drive and zero-filled the drive and one-filled the drive and random-filled the drive and removed the expansion card from the computer. In the kitchen he found a matchbook on a wooden shelf above the concrete counter and in the cabinets a half-empty bottle of port and a sack of charcoal briquettes and a can of lighter fluid. The parakeets fluttered away as he stepped out onto the terrace. Down on the beach he lifted the grate from the grill and dumped in some charcoal briquettes and poured on some lighter fluid and then put back the grate and struck a match and lit a blaze. Gripping a pair of steel tongs, he carefully set the expansion card down on the grill and watched the expansion card smoke and crackle and melt in the heat for a while and then plucked the expansion card up from the grill, charred and deformed, and threw the expansion card into the sea.

Afterward he sat in a canvas deckchair on the beach, breathing. The sky was violet-pink in the dusk. He wondered if the Russians would ever discover that he was responsible for the hack. He wondered if the Russians had already discovered that he was responsible for the hack. He thought that if the Russians knew that he was responsible for the hack, the Russians would have him hunted down and killed by any means necessary. Blasted with a pistol or slashed with a razor or strung up by a bedsheet or punched and dragged and forcibly drowned. A million-ruble bounty for the job. He drank a sip of port from the bottle. He thought about his mother and he thought about his father and he thought about his childhood. ~el8 and b4b0 and h0no and zf0. Boxy's eyeliner. Stars were glimmering in the sky above the sea. He glanced back, looking at the overlapping silhouettes of the palm trees beyond the house. Cracks of light were shining through the gaps between the slats of the bamboo shades hanging in the windows, and past the shadowy forms of the leather sofa and the leather recliner and the potted jade plant a salt lamp was glowing on the nightstand, illuminating the abstract oil painting on the wall above the bed, a monochromatic sequence of intersecting polygons. Noticing a flowering frangipani tree near the steps to the terrace, he became aware that he could smell the sweet tart fragrance of the blossoms. At that moment a gust of wind blew a flurry of petals tumbling across the sand. Even if the death was violent and painful and bloody, he thought, it would be a beautiful place to die.

About The Author

Matthew Baker is the author of the graphic novel *The Sentence*, the story collections *Why Visit America* and *Hybrid Creatures*, and the children's novel *Key Of X*. Digital experiments include the temporal fiction "Ephemeral," the interlinked novel *Untold*, the randomized novel *Verses*, and the intentionally posthumous *Afterthought*.

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